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Cold War lessons for the AI era

By **AARON MAK** | 02/26/2026 04:00 PM EST

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Hawkish fears about falling behind China are helping to drive forward American AI development.

However, some scholars, activists and proponents of AI regulation warn the race between the two countries could get out of hand. They fear that, in a blind rush to get ahead, both are creating systems that could eventually pose cataclysmic risks with few guardrails.

So how do we preserve the productive benefits of competition while ensuring that this technology is built and used responsibly? There's a growing body of literature and even a few initiatives that have looked to the Cold War for answers.

Even when concerns about the potential for direct conflict between the U.S. and the Soviet Union reached their peak during the 20th century, the two superpowers managed

to strike some critical agreements to reduce the chance of nuclear war. Some in the AI safety space suggest that similar pacts with China could help mitigate existential threats posed by future superintelligent systems.

Peter Wildeford, policy head of the AI Policy Network, told DFD, “We’ve had very fierce competition with the Soviets, and did not trust the Soviets at all, but we were still able to make mutually verified treaties.”

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But just how strong are the parallels between the current AI race, and the nuclear weapons race?

It’s not a perfect analogue, but Stanford nuclear weapons historian David Holloway suggests there were a few key moments in the Cold War era that could be relevant to AI. A major one was the establishment of the International Atomic Energy Agency in 1957, which was first proposed by President Dwight D. Eisenhower. The agency facilitated the proliferation of nuclear energy to other nations, and was crucial in beginning to build an international security framework.

“The whole system of security was extremely important in the management of the nuclear world,” Holloway told DFD. “If you are thinking of governance of AI, that’s one thing that you could draw some lessons from.” While the IAEA has received criticism as of late, Holloway says it demonstrates that focusing on the productive and peaceful uses of a technology helps to get buy-in from allies and rivals alike. As the U.S. was spreading nuclear energy abroad, the Soviet Union decided that it would be prudent to cooperate, as it also wanted to have influence in countries that were eager to develop a new energy source.

Attempts to reach nuclear weapons agreements began in earnest after the Cuban Missile Crisis and the Berlin Crisis, incidents that brought the world to the brink of nuclear war. “There was a recognition that, even if you got in the first strike in the nuclear war, the other side would be able to retaliate in a way that would just destroy your society,” said Holloway.

While it hopefully won't take a similar kind of emergency to reach AI agreements, RAND senior defense policy researcher Edward Geist said the crises at least started a constructive dialogue between the Americans and the Soviets. According to Geist, initial pacts like the 1963 Limited Test Ban Treaty actually didn't set up any particularly substantive guardrails. But coming to the table helped establish that there was a mutual interest in preventing surprise nuclear attacks, which laid the groundwork for more meaningful treaties down the line. "It was a slog, it took a long time, but it ultimately worked," Geist told DFD.

Former U.S. President Joe Biden and Chinese President Xi Jinping may already have taken that initial step. In 2024, they came to an agreement that AI shouldn't be allowed to make decisions about the use of nuclear weapons. Geist says this pact probably won't have any immediate effects, since hardly anyone was advocating for AI nuclear weapon systems in the first place. But again, just starting the discussion is critical. "We need to try and develop starting points for conversation where we can," Geist said.

There are, however, some major differences between the AI and nuclear weapons races. For one, researchers had a relatively good understanding of what nukes were capable of by the middle of the 20th century. By contrast, we don't currently know how powerful AI might be in the future. Geist told DFD, "The science behind nuclear weapons was so much better understood than the science behind AI now."

Moreover, the uranium controls devised in the 1940s eventually evolved into a decent mechanism for limiting the development of nukes, since the element is crucial for nuclear technology. There isn't a component for AI that's both as scarce and crucial. Plus, satellites can detect signs of uranium buildups. "AI is not concentrated and observable in quite the same way," said Holloway.

Yet Wildeford contends that monitoring semiconductor supply chains and the energy use of massive data centers could work in a somewhat similar way. "We're basically tracking global compute, verifying what's happening in data centers and building agreements that work without trust," he said.

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AI POLICYMAKERS PUZZLE OVER HEGSETH'S ANTHROPIC ULTIMATUM

Former officials are baffled by Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth's demand for Anthropic to give the department full access to Claude, POLITICO's Brendan Bordelon reports.

Hegseth told Anthropic CEO Dario Amodei on Tuesday that Claude would be designated a "risk" to the supply chain if the startup doesn't abandon ethical red lines over how its AI technology is used. The label is usually applied to companies from adversarial nations, and can result in a ban on working with the government. Yet Hegseth also threatened to use the Defense Production Act to force Anthropic to remove its ethical guardrails.

Dean Ball, a former AI adviser in the Trump White House, said that making the two threats simultaneously is puzzling. "You're telling everyone else who supplies to the DOD you cannot use Anthropic's models, while also saying that the DOD must use Anthropic's models," he told POLITICO.

"I don't know how you can both use the DPA to take over this product and also at the same time say this product is a massive national security risk," said Katie Sweeten, who formerly served as the Justice Department's point of contact with the Pentagon.

"Our nation requires that our partners be willing to help our warfighters win in any fight," DOD spokesperson Sean Parnell told POLITICO in a statement. "Ultimately, this is about our troops and the safety of the American people."

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